binding presence. As 'R', a former R&AW official specialising on Afghanistan and Pakistan, explains, Massoud's death was 'a blow to India'.[157] However, India's political dilemma was mild given Qanooni, Abdullah, and Fahim's presence in important cabinet portfolios ranging from defence to foreign affairs.

Second, India realised that selective engagement with non-Pashtun factions would not work in the post-Bonn context. Shyam Saran, who crafted India's diplomatic engagement in Afghanistan as foreign secretary, categorically says that 'yes, we had very close linkages with the Northern Alliance [United Front] people, but now [post Bonn] we had to broaden our constituency there [Afghanistan] and therefore we also started reaching out to the Pashtuns, including Karzai himself.'[158] Narayanan confirms this aspect of India's outreach to the Pashtuns.[159] With the baggage of having supported the Soviets first and non-Pashtuns afterwards, India wanted to come out of the jinx of being seen as a biased player in Afghanistan. Once again, changing dynamics on the ground as well as external pressures, brought the conciliators to the fore, ensuring that India did not lose out on Karzai.[160] New Delhi airlifted forty tonnes of medical supplies to Dushanbe in October 2001 to support the UF fighters,[161] immediately offered a US$ 100 million worth line of credit to Kabul, dispatched doctors and paramedics, pledged one million tonnes of wheat for internally and externally displaced Afghans, and promised to develop infrastructure projects.[162] What began as a humanitarian footprint eventually became a developmental footprint.[163] Such was India's determination to engage with Afghanistan (read Karzai) that it also gagged Abdullah (by putting a heavy police cordon around him when he came to Delhi after the conference) from speaking to the media, lest he made an anti-Pakistan or anti-Karzai statement from Indian soil, just like Qanooni had done soon after landing in India from Bonn, causing New Delhi considerable embarrassment.[164]

As the next chapter details, after Bonn, India adjusted to its traditional approach, which was Afghanistan is Afghanistan, and not a potpourri of ethnic fragments. 'Probably it would not be wrong to say that we [India] felt the need to compensate a little bit the Pashtuns and therefore we may have made a little extra effort to reach out to the Pashtuns, but even that I would say is easy to overstate', says Gautam Mukhopadhaya, India's ambassador to Kabul (2010–13).[165] The